



Handout 6.8: Station Card, Cheesy Pasta Marinara

Print one per station on card stock and one per student on paper. Post the station copy at eye level where the whole team can read it.

Station: ____ **Date:** ____ **Students at this station:** ____

The clock

PREP 0 to 10 | COOK 10 to 28 | PLATE AND EAT 28 to 35 | CLEAN 35 to 40

THE CRITICAL PATH: the water. It takes about 8 minutes to boil and the pasta takes 8 to 10 minutes more. Nothing else can finish until the pasta is drained. **The pot is on the burner on HIGH by minute 3 or this period does not work.**

Minute: 0 5 10 15 20 25 28 35 40
 Water: |====BOIL====|
 Pasta: |=====COOK=====|DRAIN|
 Sauce: |=====warm on LOW=====|
 Cheese: |portion| |on the plates|
 Plates: |set up | |serve |eat |
 Clean: |as you go, all period |ZONES|

Before any heat: the six-step routine

1. Hair back
2. Sleeves up
3. Wash hands (soap, warm water, 20 seconds)
4. Sanitize surfaces
5. Clean as you go
6. Station check before dismissal

What is on your station

Food	Amount
Pasta, spaghetti or elbows	1 lb box
Marinara sauce	1 jar, 24 oz
Shredded mozzarella	1 1/2 cups (measured and leveled)
Salt for the water	1 Tablespoon
Tools	Count
Large pot	1
Small saucepan	1
Colander (already in the sink)	1
Large serving bowl	1
Wooden spoon	1
Serving spoon or tongs	1
Measuring spoons, dry measuring cup	1 set
Plates, forks, napkins	7 each
Oven mitts	2
Trivet	1
Sanitizing spray and cloths	1 and 2

The steps

PREP, minutes 0 to 10

1. Everybody: the six-step routine. Hair, sleeves, hands, surfaces.
2. **Head Cook and Helper Cook:** fill the large pot about **three quarters** full of cold water. Two people carry it. Set it on the burner with the **handle turned in**. Turn the burner to **HIGH**. Add **1 Tablespoon of salt**. This happens by minute 3.
3. **Second Cook:** open the marinara jar. Pour it all into the small saucepan. Do not turn the heat on yet. At **minute 8**, set that burner to **LOW**.
4. **Prep Cook:** measure **1 1/2 cups** of shredded mozzarella into the small bowl. Level it with a straight edge. Do not pour from the bag.
5. **Toppings Chief:** divide the cheese into 7 small portions, one per plate, so nobody takes all of it.
6. **Station Manager:** check the drawer map. Set 7 plates, 7 forks, napkins. Clear the box and the jar the moment they are empty.
7. **Plate Builder:** set the large serving bowl and the tongs on the counter. Confirm the colander is in the sink.
8. Everybody: mise en place done before any pasta goes in the water.

COOK, minutes 10 to 28

9. **Head Cook:** watch for a **rolling boil**. That means big bubbles breaking the surface, not small bubbles on the bottom. Small bubbles are not a boil.
10. **Head Cook:** at the rolling boil, add all the pasta at once. **Stir immediately** so it does not clump, then stir again every 2 to 3 minutes.
11. **Time Keeper or Station Manager:** set the timer for the box time **minus 1 minute**. Call the time out loud every 5 minutes.
12. **Second Cook:** stir the sauce every 2 minutes. Keep it on **LOW**. Warm, not bubbling.
13. **Helper Cook:** at the timer, take one piece out with a clean fork, blow on it, and taste. Call **“soft with a little bite”** or **“not yet.”**
14. **Head Cook:** when the call is “soft with a little bite,” turn the burner **OFF** and **step back**. **The teacher drains the pasta. No student carries the pot.**
15. **Head Cook:** put the drained pasta in the serving bowl. **Second Cook:** pour the warm sauce over it. Toss gently with the tongs.
16. **Station Manager:** wash the measuring tools, the spoon, and the empty jar as they free up, so the sink is clear before clean time.

PLATE AND EAT, minutes 28 to 35

17. **Plate Builder:** serve 7 portions with the tongs, even amounts.
18. **Toppings Chief:** sprinkle the cheese on each plate **while the pasta is still hot**, so it melts.
19. **Station Manager:** count the plates. Everyone has one before anyone sits.
20. Eat.

CLEAN, minutes 35 to 40

21. Work your clean-up zone. Zones are on the chart at your station.
22. **Station Manager:** walk the station check below and report “done” to the teacher.

What does DONE look like?

Step	Done looks like
The water	Big bubbles breaking the whole surface, steam rising, the pot loud
The pasta	A piece you bite is soft all the way through with the smallest firmness in the middle. Not crunchy. Not mush
The sauce	Steam coming off it, warm all through, no bubbles popping. Not scorched on the bottom
The plate	Even portion, sauce on top, cheese melting into it, served hot
The station	Every line on the station check below is true

What could go wrong

Problem	Why it happened	The fix
The pasta is stuck in a clump	It was not stirred right after it went in	Stir the second it hits the water, then every 2 to 3 minutes. Next time, stir sooner
The pasta is mushy	It cooked too long	Set the timer for 1 minute less than the box and taste. You can always cook it longer; you cannot uncook mush
The sauce tastes burnt	The burner was above LOW and the bottom scorched	LOW only, and stir every 2 minutes. Once the bottom scorches, the whole pan tastes like it
The cheese will not melt	The pasta cooled before the cheese went on	Cheese goes on the plate while the pasta is steaming, not after
The water is not boiling at minute 12	The pot was too full, or it was not on HIGH, or it went on late	Three quarters full, HIGH, on the burner by minute 3
Somebody reached for the pot	Forgot the rule	The teacher drains. Every time. Step back and say "ready"

Station check

Line	Done?
Both burners OFF	
Pot, saucepan, and colander washed, dried, and in the drawer per the map	
Stovetop wiped	
All counters wiped and sanitized	



Plates, forks, spoons, bowl washed and put away	
Sink empty and rinsed	
Leftover cheese covered and in the fridge, or in the trash	
Floor swept	
Trash out, liner replaced	
Fridge door closed	

Teacher signature: _____

Words we say out loud at this station

English	Spanish
Behind you	
Hot	
Boiling	
Done	
Help	

Allergy note for this lab

This recipe contains **wheat** (pasta), **dairy** (cheese), and some marinara jars carry a **soy** or shared-equipment statement. If you have an allergy on the nurse's list, I have already set your role and your portion. Come see me before the timer starts.

Cost of this station

Item	Price
Pasta, 1 lb store brand	\$1.29
Marinara, 24 oz store brand	\$2.49
Shredded mozzarella, 2 bags at 8 oz	\$5.98
Salt	pantry
Total	about \$9.76
Per person at 7	about \$1.39



No-kitchen version: Cold Noodle Bowl

Same clock, same roles, same station check. Nothing is heated.

Food	Amount
Pasta, cooked and chilled the day before, or shelf stable noodles	1 lb
Shredded or cubed cheese	1 cup
Canned corn, drained	1 can
Canned black beans, drained and rinsed	1 can
Italian dressing or pesto	1 bottle or jar
Bowls and forks	7 each

PREP 0 to 10: same routine. Prep Cook opens and drains the cans in the colander and rinses the beans. Toppings Chief measures the cheese. Station Manager sets bowls and forks. Plate Builder sets the large bowl.

“COOK” 10 to 28: Head Cook combines the noodles, corn, and beans in the large bowl. Second Cook measures **1/2 cup of dressing** and adds it in two halves, tossing between. Helper Cook tastes and calls “more dressing” or “enough.” Prep Cook and Toppings Chief portion into 7 bowls. Station Manager washes as they go.

PLATE AND EAT 28 to 35 and CLEAN 35 to 40: the same as above, minus the burners.

Cost: about \$11 per station. Pasta \$1.29, cheese \$2.99, corn \$0.99, beans \$0.99, dressing \$2.49, bowls and forks about \$2.